

2026 FALL THEATER

A top 10 for autumn: Culture wars, campus controversies and epic change. Plus, reasons for optimism in cultural Chicago

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Railroad mergers heighten concerns

Ownership structures trigger period of tension, uncertainty

By John Lippert FOR THE CHICAGO TRIBUNE

When Karen Darch started agitating in 2007 for an underpass so U.S. Route 14 can pass beneath the Canadian National railroad tracks in Barrington, she had six children and no grandkids.

Nineteen years later, as workers are shattering the affluent quiet of her suburban street by pounding retaining walls for the underpass into place, she has seven grandchildren.

Darch says she can't say how many grandchildren she'll have when the half-mile, \$94 million underpass is finally complete, hopefully by the end of next year.

But now, Darch is confronting a problem that could aggravate her grandchildren for decades to come.

That problem is a new round of mergers that's putting the ownership structure of North American railroads through a blender and triggering a prolonged period of tension and uncertainty.

Union Pacific, in tandem with its \$85 billion takeover bid for Norfolk Southern, has agreed to start running more trains over Canadian National's suburban Chicago network. At the outset, this will include rerouting some trains now running through inner-city Chicago.

Darch, an attorney who served as Barrington's village president for 20 years until last year, says she believes that sooner or later, the railroads will build a second freight track through Barrington, a suburb 35 miles northwest of Chicago. That's because Canadian National has already spent years double-tracking the line to within 10 miles south of Barrington, she said.

In theory, rail experts say, this second track could mean dozens of additional Canadian National and Union Pacific freight trains roll-

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'How do we heal?'

One year after Operation Midway Blitz, a changed Chicago forges on after the resistance

By Andrew Carter, Caroline Kubzansky, Gregory Royal Pratt and Laura Rodríguez Presa | CHICAGO TRIBUNE

People in Little Village used to go to Baltazar Enríquez's office to get their whistles. He estimates he handed out thousands last year during the immigration raids that roiled Chicago and its surrounding suburbs.

When they walk in now, it's not whistles they're after. It's empathy. Someone to listen. A moment to vent or to grieve in the aftermath of what the administration of President Donald Trump touted as Operation Midway Blitz.

"How do we heal?" Enríquez, the president of the Little Village Community Council, asked recently. "That's the part we're learning."

It has been a year since the blitz commenced with the detainment of a man selling flowers in nearby Archer Heights. What began there, on the corner of South Archer Avenue and South Pulaski Road, with Leodegario Martínez Barradas dropping his flowers while federal agents handcuffed him and led him away, quickly spread throughout

Above: A tamale vendor sets up a stand at the intersection of South Archer Avenue and South Pulaski Road in the Archer Heights neighborhood on Aug. 28. This is the intersection where Leodegario Martínez Barradas, a flower vendor, was the first person detained in Chicago during Operation Midway Blitz. **E. JASON WAMBSGANS/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Chicago.

It left tamale carts deserted. Landscaping equipment abandoned. Cars on the side of the road, with keys still in the ignition. People, gone.

For 64 days, the city and its suburbs came to be under siege. For 64 days, starting with the detainment of the flower vendor on Sept. 7, 2025, and ending in November with Border Patrol agents posing for a mocking class picture in Millennium Park, their leader Gregory Bovino in the middle, the federal government carried out a militarized immigration enforcement operation under the guise of making Chicago safer.

How is it, then, that a year later, people can feel so unsafe?

The U.S. Department of Homeland Security asserted that it would target "the worst of the worst."

"Operation Midway Blitz achieved what Chicago's sanctuary politicians have refused to do for decades: decrease crime and remove the worst

See BLITZ on Page A12

Local victims, heroes of 9/11 remembered 25 years later

By Angie Leventis Lourgos CHICAGO TRIBUNE

The mysterious call came in around 7:40 a.m. on Sept. 11, 2001.

Sue Mladenik was making the bed in her Hinsdale home and quickly grabbed a nearby phone, hoping the unusually early noise wouldn't awaken her young daughter.

But after the mother said hello, there was nothing but a dial tone.

The screen of the landline only offered the cryptic message "no data sent," with no other information on the caller or number on the other end of the line.

A few minutes later, the terror

began.

Through clear blue skies, traveling faster than 400 miles per hour, American Airlines Flight 11 struck the north tower of the World Trade Center in New York.

The Boeing 767 crashed between the 93rd and 99th floors, soon felling the iconic skyscraper and instantly killing the 87 passengers and crew aboard the plane.

Watching in horror as news channels replayed footage of that scene over and over, Sue Mladenik would think about that strange disconnected phone call she received just before the jetliner

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Sue Mladenik holds a photo of her husband, Jeffrey Mladenik, in her home in Sugar Grove on Aug. 20. Jeffrey was a passenger on American Airlines Flight 11, and was killed when his plane was hijacked by terrorists and struck the World Trade Center's north tower on Sept. 11, 2001. **EILEEN T. MESLAR/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

INSIDE

Ishbia shares vision for new Sox stadium

Justin Ishbia on Saturday unveiled his plan for a new White Sox ballpark on the banks of the Chicago River in the South Loop in a development plan called the Railyards. **Sports**

Debate steps up over city building code

Allowing single-stair complexes could create needed housing, but safety concerns from the fire department loom in discussions about the ordinance. **Chicagoland, Page A3**

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